

Tsunami Survival Guide — Natural Warning Signs and Evacuation

This guide covers how to recognise a tsunami before an official warning is issued, how to evacuate immediately, and what to do after the waves. Based on UNESCO-IOC, NDMA, NOAA, and Red Cross guidelines. India's eastern coastline (Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Odisha) and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands are at significant tsunami risk.

THE MOST IMPORTANT RULE: Do NOT wait for an official alert. For locally-generated tsunamis (from a nearby earthquake), waves can arrive in minutes — before any warning system can respond. If you see or feel the natural warning signs, run immediately.

SECTION 1: THE THREE NATURAL WARNING SIGNS

If you experience ANY ONE of the following while near the coast, treat it as a tsunami warning and evacuate immediately without waiting for confirmation:

SIGN 1 — Strong or prolonged earthquake: If you feel an earthquake that lasts 20 seconds or longer while you are near the coast, move to higher ground immediately after the shaking stops. Do not wait to see if waves come.

SIGN 2 — The sea pulls back suddenly: If the sea retreats rapidly, exposing the ocean floor, rocks, and fish in areas that are normally underwater, this is called drawback. A tsunami is likely coming. Run immediately — you may have less than 2 minutes.

SIGN 3 — A loud roaring sound from the ocean: A sound like a jet aircraft or freight train coming from the direction of the sea is a warning that a wave wall is approaching. Run immediately.

CRITICAL: You do not need to see all three signs. Any one of them is enough reason to run to higher ground immediately. If you can see the wave approaching, you are already too close to outrun it.

SECTION 2: EVACUATING IMMEDIATELY

Step 1. Move to higher ground immediately. Target elevation of at least 30 metres (100 feet) above sea level, or at least 3 kilometres inland. Every metre of elevation gained increases your safety.

Step 2. If you have a car, use it — but only if roads are not already congested. In many tsunamis, people have been trapped in cars on clogged evacuation routes. If roads are gridlocked, abandon the car and run on foot.

Step 3. Do NOT drive toward the shore to see what is happening or to help others — you will be swept away. Do NOT go to the beach to watch the waves.

Step 4. Follow tsunami evacuation route signs if they are posted in your area. In India, NDMA has installed directional signs in high-risk coastal zones.

Step 5. If you cannot reach high ground in time, go to the highest floor (at least the 3rd floor) of the nearest tall, reinforced concrete building. A multi-story hotel or government building is far better than a house.

Step 6. As an absolute last resort if you are caught on low ground with no building nearby, climb the strongest tree available.

DO NOT use bridges or overpasses during a tsunami evacuation. They are choke points that can trap you, and tsunami water force can collapse them.

SECTION 3: TSUNAMI WAVES ARE NOT ONE WAVE

A tsunami is a series of waves, not a single event. This is the most important and most misunderstood fact about tsunamis.

The first wave is often NOT the largest. Subsequent waves — which may arrive 5 to 60 minutes after the first — are frequently more destructive.

Dangerous wave activity can continue for several hours.

Do NOT return to the coast until authorities issue a formal all-clear. Thousands of people have been killed by later waves after returning to check on their homes after the first wave.

SECTION 4: IF YOU ARE SWEEPED INTO THE WATER

If you are caught in the waves:

Step 1. Grab onto any floating object — debris, a wooden plank, a door, a tree trunk. Use it as a raft.

Step 2. Do not try to swim against the current. Tsunami currents are extraordinarily powerful. Conserve energy.

Step 3. Protect your head from debris impacts with your arms.

Step 4. When the current slows, work toward the edge of the flow and look for something fixed to hold onto.

SECTION 5: AFTER THE TSUNAMI

Return home only when authorities declare it safe.

Before entering any building, check for structural damage from the outside. Do not enter if you see leaning walls, large cracks in the foundation, or a sagging roof.

Do not touch electrical equipment or switches if there is water around them. Electrocution risk remains high after a tsunami.

Do not use tap water until it is declared safe. Tsunami water contaminates all ground-level water supplies with salt water, sewage, and chemicals.

Throw away all food that has been in contact with tsunami water, including canned goods with damaged seals.

Be aware that floodwater left behind by the tsunami contains sewage, chemicals, debris, and potentially dangerous animals. Wear rubber boots and gloves during any cleanup.

MENTAL HEALTH: Surviving a tsunami is a traumatic experience. Nightmares, anxiety, and fear of the sea afterward are completely normal responses. Seek support from family, community health workers, or mental health services when they become available.